COMPTIA SECURITY+ SY0-701 | DOMAIN 2 · THREATS, VULNERABILITIES, AND MITIGATIONS (22%)

Security+ 2.4 · Denial of Service

Mestre CyberSec · **Lesson 2.4 — Denial of Service** (6:07) · Assistir Vídeo no YouTube ↗ · Treino Interativo: edusouzamarques.github.io/cybersec

Executive Lesson Summary: DoS (uma origem) derruba serviço; DDoS (distribuído — botnet de milhares de máquinas). Técnicas: amplification (requisição GRANDE pra servidor aberto que amplifica); SYN flood (meio handshake TCP deixa conexões penduradas); ICMP/ping flood. Defesa: CDN (Cloudflare/Akamai na frent

💡 Key Exam Highlights & Critical Concepts

- DoS/DoS: uma origem; DDoS: botnet de milhares — amplifica
- Amplification attack: req de 50 bytes gera resposta de 4000 (DNS/NTP abertos)
- Defesa principal: CDN / CloudFlare — absorve na borda antes de chegar

🎯 Exam Tips & Typical CompTIA Scenarios

- 'thousands of machines send traffic simultaneously' = DDoS
- 'uses DNS or NTP servers to amplify traffic' = amplification attack

🚨 Beyond the Video: Official Exam Concepts, Protocols & Traps (Section 2.4 — Denial of Service)

Why is this advanced coverage required for SY0-701?: Video lectures provide foundational concepts, but CompTIA tests practical engineering judgment and requires deep familiarity with the following protocols, acronyms, and operational nuances in this domain:

• Denial of Service (DoS)

An attack launched from a single source that floods a service with traffic or exploits a weakness to make it unavailable to legitimate users.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Se o enunciado diz 'single source', 'one machine' ou 'uma única origem', a resposta é DoS — nunca DDoS.*

• Distributed Denial of Service (DDoS)

A coordinated DoS attack originating from thousands of compromised hosts simultaneously, making it very difficult to block by a single source IP.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Gatilho clássico: 'thousands of machines send traffic simultaneously' = DDoS (e normalmente envolve botnet).*

• Botnet

A network of compromised devices (bots or zombies) remotely controlled by a command-and-control (C2) server and used to launch DDoS, spam, or crypto-mining campaigns.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Botnet é a FONTE do DDoS; os dispositivos infectados pertencem a terceiros, por isso bloquear por IP quase nunca funciona.*

• Amplification Attack (Reflection)

An attack that sends a small spoofed request to an open third-party server (DNS, NTP, ICMP broadcast) so its much larger response is sent to the victim.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *'Pequena requisição gera resposta enorme' ou 'uses DNS or NTP servers to amplify traffic' = amplification/reflection attack (ex.: 50 bytes → 4000 bytes).*

• SYN Flood

A TCP DoS attack that sends many SYN packets with spoofed source addresses, filling the connection backlog with half-open sessions until real clients cannot connect.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *'Half-open TCP handshake deixando conexões penduradas' = SYN flood; defesa-chave: SYN cookies / firewalls stateful.*

• ICMP Flood (Ping Flood)

A volume-based attack that overwhelms a target with ICMP Echo Request packets, consuming bandwidth and processing resources until the service degrades.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *ICMP/ping flood é ataque VOLUME-based (banda); distinga do SYN flood, que é de PROTOCOLO/estado (esgota a tabela de conexões).*

• Content Delivery Network (CDN)

A geographically distributed set of edge servers that cache content and absorb/filter malicious traffic at the border before it reaches the origin server.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Defesa principal de DDoS citada pelo Messer: CDN (Cloudflare/Akamai) absorve na borda — a origem nunca vê o volume total do ataque.*

• Rate Limiting

A mitigation control that caps the number of requests accepted from a source or per session, reducing the impact of flooding and brute-force traffic.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Complemento da CDN/WAF na defesa contra DoS: se a questão fala em 'limitar requisições por origem', pense em rate limiting, não em criptografia.*

✅ Authentic Practice Questions (10 Real Exam Scenarios)

Scenario-based exam questions. Complete explanations and distractor analysis are provided in the answer key below.

QUESTION 1 · EXAM SCENARIO

An online retailer's website becomes unreachable during a peak sales period. The NOC reports inbound traffic from thousands of unique public IP addresses across multiple countries, all requesting the same product pages. No single source IP dominates the traffic. Which type of attack is most likely occurring?

A) A reflected DNS amplification attack

B) A distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) attack

C) A TCP SYN flood

D) An ICMP echo flood

QUESTION 2 · EXAM SCENARIO

A security analyst notices that an organization's public DNS server is receiving many small queries with spoofed source IP addresses set to a victim's IP address. The server sends large DNS responses to the victim, saturating the victim's internet link. Which technique is being used?

A) TCP SYN flood

B) ICMP ping flood

C) DNS reflection/amplification attack

D) HTTP slow POST attack

QUESTION 3 · EXAM SCENARIO

A web server's connection table is full of half-open TCP connections. Clients are sending SYN packets but never completing the three-way handshake, preventing legitimate users from connecting. Which attack is described?

A) SYN flood attack

B) DNS amplification attack

C) ICMP flood attack

D) Slowloris attack

QUESTION 4 · EXAM SCENARIO

A branch office router experiences high CPU utilization. Network monitoring shows a large volume of ICMP echo requests arriving from many different internet hosts, and the router is replying to each request. Which attack is most likely?

A) SYN flood

B) DNS amplification

C) ICMP flood

D) HTTP flood

QUESTION 5 · EXAM SCENARIO

A gaming company's servers are flooded with attack traffic originating from thousands of compromised home routers and IP cameras. The devices receive commands from an external command-and-control server. Which term best describes the collection of compromised devices?

A) Botnet

B) Content delivery network

C) Virtual private network

D) Load balancer

QUESTION 6 · EXAM SCENARIO

A company wants to reduce the impact of a large volumetric DDoS attack against its public website without moving the application to a new data center. Which mitigation is most appropriate?

A) Deploy a content delivery network with DDoS scrubbing and edge caching.

B) Install additional RAM in the web servers.

C) Enable full-disk encryption on the database servers.

D) Rotate SSH keys on the load balancer.

QUESTION 7 · EXAM SCENARIO

An API gateway is being abused by a single authenticated client that sends thousands of requests per second, causing legitimate users to receive errors. The security team wants to limit the number of requests allowed from that client while preserving normal access for others. Which control should be implemented?

A) DNSSEC on the public DNS zone

B) Rate limiting on the API gateway

C) Full-disk encryption on API servers

D) 802.1X on wireless access points

QUESTION 8 · EXAM SCENARIO

An organization discovers that an internet-facing UDP service is being used in an amplification attack. Attackers send spoofed requests to the service, and the service returns large responses to victims. Which mitigation best reduces this specific risk?

A) Disable unnecessary UDP services and apply anti-spoofing ingress filtering.

B) Enable TLS 1.3 for all UDP services.

C) Deploy host-based antivirus on employee laptops.

D) Increase password complexity for service accounts.

QUESTION 9 · EXAM SCENARIO

During a DDoS attack, a company's web servers show normal CPU and memory usage, but the internet connection is completely saturated. Which mitigation is most appropriate for this type of attack?

A) Install additional RAM in the web servers.

B) Use a CDN with DDoS scrubbing and traffic filtering.

C) Enable database indexing for the product catalog.

D) Rotate SSH keys on the load balancer.

QUESTION 10 · EXAM SCENARIO

An online service is suffering an application-layer HTTP flood from a botnet. The requests look like normal page views, but they are arriving at a very high rate and exhausting server resources. Which mitigation strategy is most appropriate?

A) Deploy a web application firewall with rate limiting and place the site behind a CDN.

B) Extend packet capture retention to 90 days.

C) Assign static IP addresses to all internal clients.

D) Enable DNSSEC on internal DNS servers.

ANSWER KEY & COMPREHENSIVE DISTRACTOR EXPLANATIONS

Question 1: Option B — A distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) attack

The key indicator is a high-volume attack from many distinct sources, which is characteristic of a DDoS attack. A DNS amplification attack would show large DNS responses, a SYN flood would show half-open TCP connections, and an ICMP echo flood would primarily be ICMP traffic. DDoS attacks often use a botnet of compromised hosts to overwhelm the target.

Question 2: Option C — DNS reflection/amplification attack

In a DNS reflection/amplification attack, the attacker sends small spoofed queries to open DNS resolvers. The resolvers send larger responses to the spoofed victim IP, amplifying the traffic. A SYN flood targets TCP connection state, an ICMP flood uses echo requests, and a slow POST attack targets application-layer resources.

Question 3: Option A — SYN flood attack

A SYN flood exploits the TCP three-way handshake by sending many SYN packets with spoofed or incomplete source addresses. The server allocates resources for half-open connections until its connection table is exhausted. Slowloris also holds connections open but typically completes the TCP handshake and sends partial HTTP requests.

Question 4: Option C — ICMP flood

An ICMP flood, also called a ping flood, overwhelms a target with ICMP echo requests. When the target replies to each request, its CPU and bandwidth can be exhausted. SYN floods target TCP state, DNS amplification uses spoofed DNS queries, and HTTP floods target web applications.

Question 5: Option A — Botnet

A botnet is a network of compromised devices, often called bots or zombies, controlled by a command-and-control server. Attackers use botnets to launch large-scale DDoS attacks. A CDN distributes content, a VPN provides encrypted remote access, and a load balancer distributes traffic to servers.

Question 6: Option A — Deploy a content delivery network with DDoS scrubbing and edge caching.

A CDN with DDoS scrubbing and edge caching can absorb and distribute volumetric attack traffic across many edge locations, protecting the origin servers. Adding RAM does not address network bandwidth exhaustion. Full-disk encryption protects data at rest, and rotating SSH keys improves access security but does not mitigate volumetric DDoS.

Question 7: Option B — Rate limiting on the API gateway

Rate limiting restricts how many requests a client can make within a specific time window, helping prevent abuse and application-layer DoS. DNSSEC protects DNS integrity, full-disk encryption protects data at rest, and 802.1X controls network access but does not limit API request volume.

Question 8: Option A — Disable unnecessary UDP services and apply anti-spoofing ingress filtering.

Amplification attacks abuse open UDP services that return large responses to spoofed source IPs. Disabling unnecessary UDP services reduces the attack surface, and ingress filtering helps prevent spoofed packets from leaving networks. TLS 1.3 is for TCP-based encryption, antivirus does not stop network amplification, and password complexity does not address spoofed UDP traffic.

Question 9: Option B — Use a CDN with DDoS scrubbing and traffic filtering.

If CPU and memory are normal but the internet link is saturated, the attack is volumetric and targets network bandwidth. A CDN with DDoS scrubbing can filter and distribute malicious traffic before it reaches the origin. Adding RAM, indexing a database, or rotating SSH keys does not address bandwidth saturation.

Question 10: Option A — Deploy a web application firewall with rate limiting and place the site behind a CDN.

An HTTP flood targets the application layer with many seemingly legitimate requests. A WAF can inspect and filter malicious HTTP traffic, rate limiting can control request volume, and a CDN can absorb distributed traffic. Packet capture retention helps forensics but does not stop the attack, static IPs do not mitigate external botnets, and DNSSEC protects DNS integrity.